PHOTOGRAPHY

BEYOND HEAVENLY

Milan Moudgill's photo project gives Kailash-Mansarovar an identity mythology cannot



Milan Moudgill didn't feel too overwhelmed when he first saw Mount Kailash in 2002. It was only during later trips to the area that the graphic designer began using words like "special" and "beautiful" to describe his experiences. "It's hard to put my finger on it," says Moudgill, "but I think what happens is that the natural beauty evokes something in you, and you retrospectively start calling that feeling 'spiritual'." Last displayed at Delhi's India Habitat Centre in early August, the photographs Moudgill took of Kailash-Mansarovar between 2002 and 2007 do something unique: by forcing us to first consider Tibetan geography instead of Hindu myths, they make secular the sacred.

Almost 20 years ago, Moudgill remembers being woken up by an insistent voice in his head at three in the morning. His unconscious had left him with a clear instruction—"You must write a book on Kailash." Soon after he started his research, he found that a lot of the literature on the area was tinged with religiosity: "These books all focused on the spirituality of the area, describing it as the centre of the universe, etc. I wanted my project to have its own niche and that only came later."

Like many other photographers, Moudgill could well have made himself

NO MOUNTAIN HIGH ENOUGH



AN INDIAN FATHER-DAUGHTER DUO IS MAKING HISTORY BY CLIMBING SOME OF THE WORLD'S TALLEST MOUNTAINS

Even before we speak, it seems clear that Ajeet and Deeya Bajaj take fitness seriously—they request for an interview after Ajeet's early morning swim—"I *have* to swim from 7 am to 8 am every day," he says. On June 5 this year, the father-daughter duo summited Denali in Alaska, which is the tallest mountain in North America, thereby becoming the first Asian parent-child team to complete the Seven Summits challenge. "Denali is right at the Arctic Circle—it's really cold and you have 24 hours of daylight," says Ajeet. Prior to the climb, they spent five days kayaking and hiking in Alaska to warm up. "It was a very good, intense climb. You're carrying about 60 kg up the mountain—all your food and supplies for the 21 days you're expected to be on the expedition," says Deeya, 28, who studies at Wharton. They completed the expedi-